

The Bible Is Not an American Book

Three languages, a dozen empires, a millennium of authors, and not one of them ever saw a ballot. The text resists every flag we drape over it, including ours.

THE ORIGIN

Written by People Who Were Not Us

The Bible was written in Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek, across something close to a millennium, by herdsmen, scribes, exiles, fishermen, a physician, and a tentmaker. Not one of them spoke English. Not one of them voted. Not one of them lived in a nation where his faith held cultural power. They wrote from the underside of Egypt, Assyria, Babylon, Persia, Greece, and Rome, empires they did not choose and could not control.

This is not trivia. It is the first fact of interpretation. Kenneth Bailey spent forty years in the Middle East showing how much of the Gospels we misread because we have never lived in a village culture of honor, hospitality, and land. The text comes from somewhere. It comes from there, not here.

I forget this constantly. I read Philippians, written by a prisoner awaiting trial under an emperor who would soon kill him, and I receive it as encouragement for a difficult week. The original readers heard a man in chains tell them their citizenship was in heaven. We hear a greeting card. The distance between those two readings is the distance this guide exists to name.

THE IMPORTS

What We Carry Through the Door

Every reader carries assumptions through the door. American readers carry three the text does not share.

First, chosen-nation typology. From Winthrop's city on a hill onward, Americans have read Israel's story as our story, the Atlantic as our Jordan, this continent as our Canaan. Mark Noll has traced how thoroughly that habit shaped American theology, until by 1861 both armies marched under the same verses. But the Bible knows one covenant nation, and it is not us. The promises to Israel land on Christ and his people gathered from every nation, not on any modern state.

Second, prosperity as blessing. Deuteronomy ties Israel's harvests to covenant faithfulness, and we

quietly transfer the equation to our portfolios and our gross domestic product. Job, Ecclesiastes, the Psalms of lament, and a crucified Messiah all protest the transfer. It survives anyway, because we want it to.

Third, rights language. Scripture is relentlessly concerned with justice, but its grammar is obligation, not entitlement. The question in the law and the prophets is not what I may claim. It is what I owe, to God and to neighbor. When I arrive demanding my rights, the text keeps asking about my debts.

THE DISTINCTION

Applying Scripture, or Projecting Ourselves

There is a difference between applying Scripture to America and reading America into Scripture. The difference decides everything.

Application moves in one direction. The text says what it said to Corinth or Judah, and then, under that fixed meaning, we ask what obedience looks like on our street. Richard Bauckham calls this taking the Bible's own political material seriously, on its own terms, before any modern use is attempted. Projection moves the other way. It starts with our nation, our party, our cause, and goes hunting for verses, and 2 Chronicles 7:14 gets stapled to a country that was never the people called by his name in that promise.

The test is whether the text can still say no to you. Applied Scripture corrects the reader. Projected Scripture only ever agrees.

I know the difference because I have done both from the same pulpit. Projection feels wonderful. The congregation nods, the nation is flattered or scolded on schedule, and nothing in me is at risk. Application costs. It once made me stand up and retract a sermon. That is how I learned which one I had been doing.

THE EVEN HAND

Two Flags Over One Text

Both political tribes project, in mirror image.

The right reads America as the new Israel. National decline becomes covenant curse, the founders become patriarchs, and a verse addressed to Solomon's temple becomes a campaign promise. The flag moves to the front of the sanctuary and no one remembers voting on it.

The left reads America as the kingdom under construction. The prophets become policy memos, Jesus becomes the first community organizer, and the state becomes the instrument by which Matthew 25 will finally be enforced. The kingdom gets a legislative calendar.

Notice what both did. Both made America the subject of the Bible. One baptized the nation's past, the

other baptized its future, and in both readings the cross is reduced to a means toward a political end the text never names. Lesslie Newbigin came home from four decades in India and saw it at once: Western Christians could critique every culture except their own.

I am not above this. I have preached the nation when I meant to preach Christ, and the sermons were well received, which should have warned me. The applause of your own tribe is not the witness of the Spirit. I learned that slowly, and at cost.

THE PRACTICE

Letting the Book Be Foreign

So how do we read a book that is not ours?

Slowly, and from somewhere else. Read Exodus as a freed slave, not as Pharaoh's countryman. Read Daniel as a deportee. Read Revelation as it was written, from a penal island, to churches deciding weekly whether to burn the pinch of incense. Ask of every passage: who held the power in this scene, and where do I actually stand in it? American readers reflexively cast ourselves as Israel, as David, as the persecuted church. Sometimes we are Babylon. Sometimes we are the rich young ruler, and the text watches us walk away sad.

Then let the strangeness stand. Do not rush the text into relevance. A Bible that never offends your politics has already been edited, whoever you are and however you vote.

The Bible is not an American book. It is older than our arguments, larger than our elections, and addressed to a people scattered across every nation and at home in none. When we finally read it that way, it stops flattering us. That is the moment it can start saving us. Most of us have not yet let it be foreign enough to do either.

KEY TEXTS

Exodus 19:4-6

Philippians 3:20-21

1 Peter 1:1-2

SOURCES

The Bible in Politics: How to Read the Bible Politically — Richard Bauckham

America's God: From Jonathan Edwards to Abraham Lincoln — Mark A. Noll

Foolishness to the Greeks: The Gospel and Western Culture — Lesslie Newbigin

Jesus Through Middle Eastern Eyes — Kenneth E. Bailey